

# Milnor's cartography problem (preliminary version)

Anton Petrunin

## Abstract

We solve John Milnor's problem: among all convex regions of a given area on the sphere, the round disk requires the greatest distortion in cartographic projections onto the plane.

Let  $\mathbb{S}^2$  be the unit sphere, equipped with the geodesic metric, and let  $\Omega \subset \mathbb{S}^2$ . Recall that a map  $f: \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  is called bi-Lipschitz if

$$L_1 \cdot |x - y|_{\mathbb{S}^2} \leq |f(x) - f(y)|_{\mathbb{R}^2} \leq L_2 \cdot |x - y|_{\mathbb{S}^2}$$

for some constants  $L_1$  and  $L_2$  and any two points  $x, y \in \Omega$ ; here  $|\cdot|_{\mathbb{S}^2}$  and  $|\cdot|_{\mathbb{R}^2}$  stand for the geodesic distance in the sphere  $\mathbb{S}^2$  and the Euclidean plane  $\mathbb{R}^2$ , respectively.

We will be interested in upper bounds on the distortion ratio  $L_2/L_1$  for a given set  $\Omega$ . In other words, given a set  $\Omega$ , we want to construct its cartographic projection with small distortion. After rescaling, we may assume that  $L_1 = 1$  (so,  $f$  is noncontracting), and we have to minimize  $L_2$ .

Let us denote by  $D_\rho$  the round disc of radius  $\rho$  in  $\mathbb{S}^2$ . It is straightforward to check that the polar coordinates with the origin at the center of  $D_\rho$  define a map  $f: D_\rho \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  with the distortion ratio  $\frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}$ . John Milnor [3] observed that this value is optimal; that is, *if  $f: D_\rho \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  is a bi-Lipschitz map, then its distortion ratio must be at least  $\frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}$ ; moreover, if the equality holds, then, up to rescaling, the map  $f$  is the same as above*. In the same paper, he formulated the following problem; a weaker version this of problem was stated in the expository article by Étienne Ghys [1].

**0.1. Problem.** *Among all convex regions in  $\mathbb{S}^2$  of a given area, the disk requires the largest distortion ratio.*

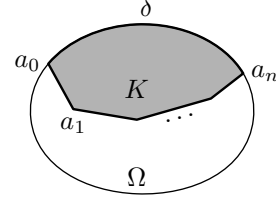
*More precisely, any closed convex set  $\Omega \subset \mathbb{S}^2$  such that  $\text{area } \Omega = \text{area } D_\rho$  admits a map  $\Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  with Lipschitz constants 1 and  $\frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}$ .*

The proof proceeds by subdividing  $\Omega$  into thin slices, such that the union of their borderlines forms a geodesic tree. This tree is developed in the plane preserving edge lengths and angles. Then the resulting map on the tree is extended to each slice. We impose a certain balancing property on the subdivision, which makes it possible to keep the distortion under control.

Our solution was found while writing a note [6] for school students on Gary Lawlor's proof of the isoperimetric inequality [2]. In fact, his construction produces a subdivision that can be used to solve a version of Milnor's problem with perimeter instead of area; this has been known for a while [4, 5].

# 1 Balanced sets

Fix a closed convex set  $\Omega \subset \mathbb{S}^2$ . A convex subset  $K \subset \Omega$  is called admissible if it is bounded by an arc of  $\partial\Omega$  and a polygonal line  $a_0a_1 \dots a_n$  joining the endpoints of this arc. The arc  $\delta = \partial\Omega \cap K$  will be called the coastline of  $K$ ; the polygonal  $a_0a_1 \dots a_n$  will be called the borderline of  $K$ ; their common endpoints  $a_0$  and  $a_n$  will be called the corners of  $K$ . Let us define the turn of  $K$  (briefly,  $\text{turn } K$ ) as the sum of exterior angles of  $K$  at  $a_1, a_2, \dots, a_{n-1}$ .



Fix  $\rho \leq \frac{\pi}{2}$  and define

$$\text{balance}_\rho K := \lambda(\rho) \cdot \text{area } K + \text{turn } K - \pi,$$

where

$$\lambda(\rho) := \frac{\text{area } D_{\frac{\pi}{2}}}{\text{area } D_\rho} = \frac{1}{1 - \cos \rho}.$$

Since  $\rho \leq \frac{\pi}{2}$ , we have  $\lambda(\rho) \geq 1$ . If  $\text{balance}_\rho K = 0$ , then  $K$  is called  $\rho$ -balanced. Note that every sector of  $D_\rho$  is a  $\rho$ -balanced set.

**1.1. Lemma.** *Any point of a  $\rho$ -balanced subset  $K$  lies at distance at most  $\rho$  from its coastline. Moreover, if the maximum distance is  $\rho$ , then  $K$  is congruent to a sector of  $D_\rho$ .*

*Proof.* Assume there is a point  $x \in K$  at distance at least  $\rho$  from the coastline. Let  $L$  be the curvilinear triangle with vertex  $x$  and the coastline as the base. Denote by  $S$  the intersection of  $L$  with the  $\rho$ -disk centered at  $x$ .

Note that  $S$  is a sector of the  $\rho$ -disk; in particular  $S$  is  $\rho$ -balanced. Furthermore,  $\text{turn } S = \text{turn } L$ , and since  $S \subset L$ , we have  $\text{area } S \leq \text{area } L$ . Therefore,

$$0 = \text{balance}_\rho S \leq \text{balance}_\rho L;$$

moreover, in the case of equality, we have  $L = S$ .

On the other hand,  $L \subset K$ , and so  $\text{area } L \leq \text{area } K$ . Furthermore, by the spherical area formula (which is a special case of the Gauss–Bonnet theorem), we get

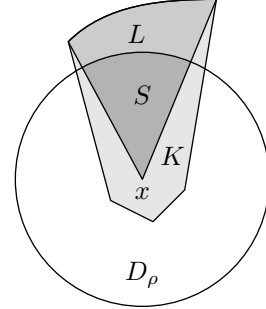
$$\text{turn } L - \text{turn } K \leq \text{area } K - \text{area } L.$$

Since  $\lambda(\rho) \geq 1$ , we have

$$0 = \text{balance}_\rho K \geq \text{balance}_\rho L;$$

moreover, in the case of equality, we have  $K = L$ , which finishes the proof.  $\square$

Let  $K$  be an admissible set and  $S$  be a sector of a disc in the sphere. We say that  $K$  is properly inscribed in  $S$  if the corners of  $K$  lie on two different sides of  $S$  and the coastline of  $K$  cuts off from  $S$  a convex set that contains the center of  $S$ .

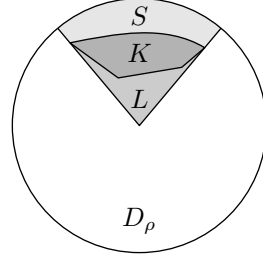


**1.2. Lemma.** *If an admissible set  $K$  is properly inscribed in a sector  $S$  of  $D_\rho$ , then  $\text{balance}_\rho K \leq 0$  and, in the case of equality, we have  $K = S$ .*

*Proof.* Let us denote by  $L$  the convex subset that is cut off from  $S$  by the coastline of  $K$ . Arguing as in 1.1, we get

$$0 = \text{balance}_\rho S \geq \text{balance}_\rho L \geq \text{balance}_\rho K.$$

If  $\text{balance}_\rho K = 0$ , then we have equalities both times, and hence  $S = L = K$ .  $\square$



## 2 Slicing

**2.1. Proposition.** *Let  $\Omega \subset \mathbb{S}^2$  be a closed convex set. If  $\text{area } \Omega = \text{area } D_\rho$ , then  $\Omega$  admits a finite subdivision into  $\rho$ -balanced sets with arbitrarily short coastlines.*

**2.2. Observation.** *Suppose that an admissible set  $K$  is subdivided into two admissible sets  $L$  and  $R$  by a chord from the borderline to the coastline. Then*

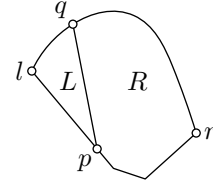
$$\text{balance}_\rho K = \text{balance}_\rho L + \text{balance}_\rho R.$$

*Proof of 2.1.* Let us split  $\Omega$  by a chord into two sets  $K_1$  and  $K_2$  of equal area. Observe that each  $K_i$  is  $\rho$ -balanced.

It remains to show that any  $\rho$ -balanced subset  $K$  can be subdivided into a finite number of  $\rho$ -balanced sets with arbitrarily short coastlines.

Let  $l$  and  $r$  be corners of  $K$ . Choose a point  $p$  on the borderline and a point  $q$  on the coastline. Then the chord  $[p, q]$  splits  $K$  into two admissible sets  $L \ni l$  and  $R \ni r$ .

If  $p$  and  $q$  are close to  $l$ , then by 1.2,  $\text{balance}_\rho L \leq 0$ , and, by the observation,  $\text{balance}_\rho R \geq 0$ . Similarly, if  $p$  and  $q$  are close to  $r$ , then by 1.2,  $\text{balance}_\rho R \leq 0$ , and  $\text{balance}_\rho L \geq 0$ . Since  $\text{balance}_\rho L$  depends continuously on the choice of the chord, we can choose a chord  $[p, q]$  that splits  $K$  into two  $\rho$ -balanced sets.



Furthermore, 1.2 implies that for any  $\varepsilon > 0$  we can choose  $\delta > 0$  such that if the coastline of  $K$  is longer than  $\varepsilon$ , then the coastline of each slice  $L$  and  $R$  is shorter than that of  $K$  by at least  $\delta$ . Therefore, repeating this construction recursively provides the needed subdivision.  $\square$

## 3 Chord foliation

**3.1. Proposition.** *Let  $K$  be an admissible set. Suppose that  $\text{balance}_\rho K \leq 0$  and every chord from the borderline to the coastline has length less than  $\rho$ . Then*

the interior of  $K$  can be foliated by chords from the borderline to the coastline such that the slice between any pair of chords, or on one side of a chord, has nonpositive  $\rho$ -balance.

*Proof.* Let  $[p, q]$  be a chord of  $K$  from the borderline to the coastline. Denote by  $L_{[p, q]}$  the part of  $K$  on the left side of  $[p, q]$ . Choose an orientation of both the borderline and the coastline of  $K$  from the left corner to the right one.

Recall that  $\rho \leq \frac{\pi}{2}$ . By the condition on chord length, the function

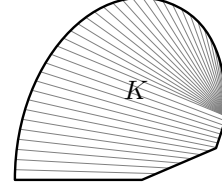
$$(p, q) \mapsto \text{balance}_\rho L_{[p, q]}$$

is increasing in  $p$  and decreasing in  $q$  with respect to the orientation. It follows that the chords  $[p, q]$  defined by the equation

$$\text{balance}_\rho L_{[p, q]} = 0$$

do not intersect and foliate a convex set  $K' \subset K$ .

If  $K' \neq K$  then the foliation has a chord with end at the right corner. In this case, the foliation can be extended by chords with an endpoint at this corner. By the condition on chord length, the extended foliation meets the conditions.  $\square$

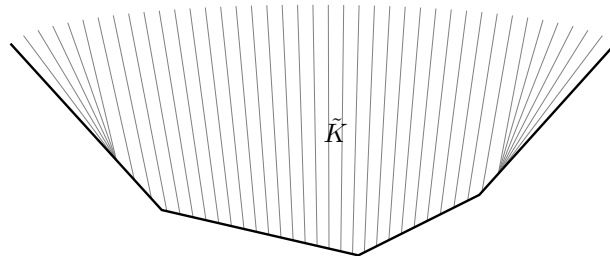


## 4 Fishbone map

Let  $\beta$  be the borderline of an admissible set  $K$ , and let  $\tilde{\beta}$  be its development in the plane; that is,  $\tilde{\beta}$  is a polygonal line in  $\mathbb{R}^2$  with side lengths and oriented angles as in  $\beta$ . Note that there is a natural length-preserving map  $\beta \rightarrow \tilde{\beta}$ .

Suppose  $\text{balance}_\rho K \leq 0$ ; in particular  $\text{turn } K < \pi$ . Then  $\tilde{\beta}$  and extensions of its first and last segments bound a convex set of  $\mathbb{R}^2$ ; let us call it the plane slice of  $K$  and denote it by  $\tilde{K}$ .

Suppose the interior of  $K$  is foliated by chords from the borderline to the coastline. For each chord  $\ell = [p, q]$  in the foliation, consider the corresponding half-line  $\tilde{\ell}$  in  $\tilde{K}$ ; it starts at the point  $\tilde{p} \in \tilde{\beta}$  that corresponds to  $p \in \beta$  and makes the same angle with  $\tilde{\beta}$ . Suppose that the original foliation is spreading; that is, every slice between two chord of the foliation, or on one side of a chord, has turn at most  $\pi$ . Then the obtained half-lines do not intersect each other and they foliate a region in the interior of  $\tilde{K}$ . There might be one or two angles



in  $\tilde{K}$  adjacent to its infinite sides that are not covered by this foliation. In this case, foliate them by the half-lines starting from the vertices of these angles; they correspond to the corners of  $K$ .

The natural map  $\beta \rightarrow \tilde{\beta}$  extends to the fishbone map  $f: K \rightarrow \tilde{K}$  that sends each chord of the foliation isometrically to the starting segment of the corresponding half-line.

**4.1. Observation.** *Let  $K$  be an admissible set such that  $\text{balance}_\rho K \leq 0$  and every chord from the borderline to the coastline has length less than  $\rho$ . Then the foliation of  $K$  provided by 3.1 induces a  $\frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}$ -Lipschitz fishbone map  $f: K \rightarrow \tilde{K}$ .*

*Proof.* Note that the fishbone map  $f$  is Lipschitz. Therefore it is differentiable almost everywhere.

Choose an oriented orthonormal frame  $v, w$  in the interior of  $K$  such that  $v$  points in the direction of the chord foliation. Further, choose an oriented orthonormal frame  $\tilde{v}, \tilde{w}$  in the interior of  $\tilde{K}$  such that  $\tilde{v}$  points in the direction of the half-line foliation.

Suppose the differential  $df$  is defined at  $x$ . In the described frames, the differential is represented by a diagonal matrix  $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & \nu \end{pmatrix}$ . It is sufficient to show that

$$(*) \quad \nu \leq \frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}.$$

Choose a chord  $\ell$ ; let  $s$  be its arc length parameter starting at its borderline point. Let  $I(s)$  be a normal Jacobi field along the chord; after rescaling, we can assume that

$$I(s) = w(s) \cdot \sin(a + s)$$

for some  $a$ . The corresponding Jacobi field in the plane is

$$\tilde{I}(s) = \tilde{w}(s) \cdot (\sin(a) + s \cdot \cos a).$$

It follows that

$$\nu(s) = \frac{\sin a + s \cdot \cos a}{\sin(a + s)}.$$

The balance condition can be written infinitesimally; the integral of  $\sin(a+t)$  plays the role of  $\text{area } K$  and  $\cos a$  plays the role of  $\pi - \text{turn } K$ . Thus, we get

$$\lambda(\rho) \cdot (\cos a - \cos(a + s)) = \lambda(\rho) \cdot \int_0^s \sin(a + t) \cdot dt \leq \cos a,$$

and therefore

$$\cos a - \cos(a + s) \leq 1 - \cos \rho.$$

Note that  $0 \leq a \leq a + s \leq \frac{\pi}{2}$ . Set

$$\mu = \cos a - \cos(a + s), \quad \nu = \frac{\sin a + s \cdot \cos a}{\sin(a + s)}.$$

A straightforward computation shows that for fixed  $\mu$ , the quantity  $\nu$  is nonincreasing as a function of  $a$ , and for fixed  $a$ , the quantity  $\nu$  is nondecreasing as a function of  $s$ . Hence  $(*)$  follows.  $\square$

The fishbone map  $f$  has a natural left inverse  $b: \tilde{K} \rightarrow \mathbb{S}^2$ ; let us call it the backbone map. It maps the half-line  $\tilde{\ell}$  in the foliation of  $\tilde{K}$  to the geodesic that extends the corresponding chord  $\ell$  in a locally distance-preserving way.

The additional half-lines in the foliation of  $\tilde{K}$  are mapped to geodesics making the same angle with  $\beta$  that start from the corners of  $K$ .

**4.2. Observation.** *Let  $K$  be an admissible set such that  $\text{balance}_\rho K \leq 0$ , and every chord from the borderline to the coastline has length less than  $\rho$ . Then the foliation of  $K$  provided by 3.1 induces a 1-Lipschitz backbone map.*

*Proof.* The proof is similar to the previous observation. We need to compare the absolute values of the plane Jacobi field

$$\tilde{I}(s) = \tilde{W}(s) \cdot (\sin a + s \cos a)$$

and the corresponding spherical Jacobi field

$$I(s) = W(s) \cdot \sin(a + s).$$

Since the foliation is spreading, we have  $\cos a \geq 0$ ; therefore

$$|\sin a + s \cdot \cos a| \geq |\sin(a + s)|$$

for any  $s \geq 0$ , and the result follows.  $\square$

*Proof of 0.1.* Since  $\Omega$  is convex, we have  $\rho \leq \frac{\pi}{2}$ . Moreover, we can assume that  $\rho < \frac{\pi}{2}$ ; otherwise,  $\Omega$  is a hemisphere and polar coordinates provide the required map.

Applying 2.1, we get a subdivision of  $\Omega$  into  $\rho$ -balanced sets  $K_1, \dots, K_m$ . The union of the borderlines of  $K_i$  is a geodesic tree; denote it by  $T$ .

Consider the development  $T$ ; it is a geodesic tree in the plane with the same edge lengths and the same oriented angles as in  $T$ . Extend the edges of the development beyond their endvertices; denote the resulting tree by  $\tilde{T}$ . Note that  $\tilde{T}$  subdivides the plane into plane slices  $\tilde{K}_1, \dots, \tilde{K}_m$  of  $K_1, \dots, K_m$ , respectively.

By 2.1, we can assume that the coastlines of  $K_i$  are shorter than a given  $\varepsilon > 0$ . Suppose  $\varepsilon$  is very small; in particular,  $\rho + \varepsilon < \frac{\pi}{2}$ . We can apply 3.1 with radius  $\rho + \varepsilon$  to each  $K_i$ . Indeed,  $\text{balance}_{\rho+\varepsilon} K_i < 0$  and 1.1 implies the condition on chord lengths.

The fishbone maps  $f_i: K_i \rightarrow \tilde{K}_i$  agree on  $T$  and therefore fit together in one map  $f: \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ . By 4.1,  $f$  is  $\frac{\rho+\varepsilon}{\sin(\rho+\varepsilon)}$ -Lipschitz.

Furthermore, the backbone maps  $b_i: \tilde{K}_i \rightarrow \mathbb{S}^2$  also agree on  $\tilde{T}$ , and they fit together in one map  $b: \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{S}^2$ , which is 1-Lipschitz by 4.2.

By the construction,  $b \circ f = \text{id}_\Omega$ . Thus  $f: \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  has Lipschitz constants 1 and  $\frac{\rho+\varepsilon}{\sin(\rho+\varepsilon)}$ . Since  $\varepsilon > 0$  can be chosen arbitrarily, Arzelà–Ascoli theorem provides a map  $f_0: \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  with Lipschitz constants 1 and  $\frac{\rho}{\sin(\rho)}$ .  $\square$

## 5 Remarks

Following this argument one can show that if  $\Omega$  is not a round disc, then there is a map with distortion ratio strictly less than  $\frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}$ . This statement can be taken as an exercise.

As we mentioned already, a straightforward limit procedure provides a map  $f_0: \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$  with optimal Lipschitz constants; this was also stated in John Milnor’s paper. We can assume that  $f_0$  has lower Lipschitz constant 1; therefore the upper Lipschitz constant  $L_2$  is minimal. In this case we expect that  $f_0$  has the following properties:

- (a) There is a subset  $X$  of  $\Omega$  such that the differential  $d_x f_0$  is an isometry for any  $x \in X$ , and the complement  $\Omega \setminus X$  has a foliation by geodesics such that  $f_0$  isometrically maps each geodesic in the foliation to a geodesic in the plane.
- (b) The local upper Lipschitz constants approach  $L_2$  at the boundary of  $\Omega$ .
- (c) If  $\Omega$  is convex then so is its image  $f_0(\Omega)$ .

**5.1. Question.** *Let  $(M, g)$  be a simply connected (noncomplete) Riemannian 2-manifold with constant curvature 1 and area equal to  $\text{area } D_\rho$ . Is there a homeomorphism from  $(M, g)$  to a flat 2-manifold with distortion ratio at most  $\frac{\rho}{\sin \rho}$ ?*

## References

- [1] É. Ghys. “Représenter les mondes”. *Images des Mathématiques* (2010). URL: <https://images-des-maths.pages.math.cnrs.fr/freeze/Representer-les-mondes.html>. [Translated by R. Matveev in É. Ghys, “Charting the Worlds”, *AMR*, 2025, <https://amathr.org/charting/>].
- [2] G. Lawlor. “A new area-maximization proof for the circle”. *Math. Intell.* 20.1 (1998), 29–31.
- [3] J. Milnor. “A problem in cartography”. *Amer. Math. Monthly* 76 (1969), 1101–1112.
- [4] A. Petrunin. *A gallery of open problems in geometry that keep me puzzled and amused*. 2025. arXiv: 2510.11908 [math.DG].
- [5] A. Petrunin. *Milnor’s cartography problem*. MathOverflow. eprint: <https://mathoverflow.net/q/5479>.
- [6] А. Петрунин. *Дидона с велосипедом*. URL: <https://anton-petrunin.github.io/papers/dido.pdf>.